

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Morning Brief — Sunday, August 16, 2026

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World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



Al Jazeera — What is Tokyo's Yasukuni Shrine, linked to Japan's wartime atrocities?



whcc.com — Top US commander visits aircraft carrier, Gaza talks in Egypt and other Mideast news - WHE



Guardian World — Logies 2026: Sam Pang wins gold and Sam Neill wins posthumous best actor at Australia's TV

1. World & Geopolitics

The lead: One story ties today's front page together: the Middle East's June ceasefire framework is being tested on every front at once — formal talks in Cairo, Israeli strikes on Lebanon, settler escalation in the West Bank, and a naval standoff in the Strait of Hormuz. Beneath it sits a quieter, bigger story: the US has almost no strategic oil cushion left at exactly the moment it might need one.

Gaza talks are happening in Cairo — fragile, but alive. A Hamas delegation (Hamas = the Palestinian group that has governed Gaza since 2007; the US and EU designate it a terrorist group) was in Cairo on Sunday for ceasefire-related talks, and US negotiator Jared Kushner (Trump's son-in-law, now acting as a US envoy) was in Egypt separately ([WHEC](#)). The talks sit inside the 60-day negotiating period that began with the June 17 signing; a ceasefire, remember, is a formal agreement to stop fighting — usually temporary, unlike a peace treaty ([WHEC](#)).

But Israel's strikes on southern Lebanon are the biggest threat to those talks since June. Saturday's strikes killed at least 11 people, targeting two Hezbollah commanders — Hezbollah being the Iran-backed Lebanese militia and political party ([ABC News](#)). Analysts describe them as the most serious breach of the peace process since the June agreement — the exact opposite of the "calm while we negotiate" the framework was supposed to buy ([France24](#)).

The West Bank is the third front — and it's moving in the opposite direction of ceasefire talks. Israel has handed West Bank policing to civilian police forces — a move Al Jazeera calls the "spearhead of annexation" ([Al Jazeera](#)). In practice, this cements de facto Israeli control and empowers settler militias, who this week besieged the Palestinian village of Qusra for seven days, cutting off supplies until the military declared it a zone ([Al Jazeera](#)). The US ambassador called settler violence "acts of terror" ([France24](#)).

The Strait of Hormuz is the fourth front — and it's escalating. President Trump said he has demanded about seven countries send warships to keep the Strait of Hormuz open, as Iran continued striking Gulf countries ([News On AIR](#)). Iran's deputy foreign minister rebuffed him, saying Hormuz "will remain Iranian" ([CNBC](#)). The Strait of Hormuz is the chokepoint (a narrow passage through which a large share of global trade must pass) for about 20% of the world's oil. The US top Middle East commander, Adm. Brad Cooper, visited the USS Lincoln in the Arabian Sea during a 10-day regional tour that ended Saturday ([ABC News](#)) — while families of the crew say Trump should be "ashamed" of the dire conditions on board after a deployment he called "not nearly long enough" ([NPR](#)).

The strategic oil cushion is nearly gone. The US Strategic Petroleum Reserve (the government's emergency stockpile of crude, held in underground salt caverns) has been drawn down so fast that experts warn the caverns themselves could be damaged ([CNBC](#)).

This is a second-order risk: the reserve exists precisely for moments like this, and it's depleted.

Iran's economy is choking. Millions of Iranians struggle to make ends meet as the war with the US devastates the economy and sends prices soaring ([Al Jazeera](#)). This is the classic pressure point of a sanctions-and-war campaign — but it cuts both ways: an economically desperate Iran has less to lose.

Ukraine launched one of its largest aerial attacks of the war. Hundreds of drones crossed into Russia on Sunday, killing at least six people ([NPR](#)). Separately, Ukraine's \$48,000 long-range drone — a clone of a Chinese design, built after covertly photographing a factory — destroyed a Russian Tu-95 strategic bomber at Engels-2 air base last month ([Tom's Hardware](#)). Russia's foreign minister Lavrov reiterated that Russia

will not accept a ceasefire that freezes the frontline, demanding a settlement on its own terms ([Daily Kos](#)).

Japan's defence minister heads to Australia to meet his counterpart, in the highest-level engagement since the "melon-gate" controversy over Prime Minister Takaichi's gift of melons to Australia's PM ([The Guardian](#)). The talks focus on Australia's acquisition of Mogami-class frigates — a sign of deepening Japan-Australia defence ties amid China's rise.

Other notable items: A ferry capsizing on Lake Kariba in Zimbabwe killed at least 80 ([France24](#)); an earthquake in Indonesia killed at least 53 and displaced thousands ([BBC](#)); Belgium's largest wildfire on record spread toward the German border ([Al Jazeera](#)); and a Connecticut Democratic primary ousted Rep. John Larson, a Social Security expansion advocate ([CNBC](#)).

2. Markets, Money & Deals

The tape: The S&P 500 hit a record high last week, driven by moderating inflation and the AI trade ([Intellectia AI](#)). Intel and Nvidia fueled the AI trade last week ([CNBC](#)). The Fed minutes this week may reveal forward guidance on rates ([Financial Times](#)). Jackson Hole, the Fed's annual symposium August 21-22, is the next catalyst ([TradingKey](#)).

Berkshire added \$17 billion to its Alphabet stake. Google parent Alphabet (GOOGL) is now the third-largest holding in Warren Buffett's Berkshire Hathaway portfolio ([CNBC](#)). This is a notable signal from the famously tech-wary Buffett.

Workday's \$51 billion takeover talks could reset the software trade. The enterprise software company is in

talks that could reshape how software companies are valued ([TheStreet](#)).

Biopharma is in a \$106 billion takeover wave. Gilead, Merck, and Eli Lilly are leading the charge in 2026 ([Stocktwits](#)).

Crypto: Coinbase CEO Brian Armstrong says crypto will power 10% of global GDP by 2030 ([Yellow.com](#)). Trump is set to meet Coinbase, Ripple, and crypto leaders as the CLARITY Act's odds collapse to 10% ([Altcoin Buzz](#)). A Gemini survey found 51% of Gen Z adults worldwide own crypto ([Yellow.com](#)). SBI Holdings launched Japan's first security token bond with built-in XRP rewards ([Yellow.com](#)).

3. AI & Infrastructure

Anthropic is closing in on a \$7 billion Decart deal, beating Nvidia to the table ([calcalistech](#)). Decart builds AI inference infrastructure — the systems that run trained models to make predictions. This is a bet on the "compute layer" of AI, and it signals Anthropic is building its own infrastructure stack rather than renting everything from hyperscalers.

Nvidia is eyeing a \$3 billion investment in SB Energy under an OpenAI data center deal ([Reuters](#)). SB Energy

is a renewable energy developer. This is Nvidia moving beyond chips into power — the clearest signal yet that power, not silicon, is the binding constraint on AI.

Meta's stock rout deepens on capex woes. META fell overnight on concerns about capital expenditure (capex — spending on long-lived assets like data centres) ([Stocktwits](#)). Analysts still back it as the cheapest Mag 7 AI bet — but the market is punishing the spending.

Palantir called Q2 "otherworldly" and raised guidance. PLTR reported 93% growth and a Rule of 40 score of 155 (Rule of 40 = revenue growth rate + profit margin; above 40 is considered excellent for software) ([TradingKey](#)). The question is whether Jackson Hole derails the AI sovereignty momentum.

OpenAI's enterprise business now bigger than consumer by revenue. CFO Sarah Friar told investors this after a week of C-suite turmoil ([CNBC](#)). This is a major inflection: AI's real customers are businesses, not individuals.

Anthropic's revenue jumped to over \$11.5 billion in Q2 ([CNBC](#)), as it prepares for a potential blockbuster IPO.

Apple is testing Chinese memory chips from CXMT for iPhones and MacBooks ([Startup Fortune](#)). This is a

seismic shift — Apple diversifying away from Samsung and SK Hynix toward a Chinese supplier, with huge geopolitical implications for the memory supply chain.

Google reportedly tapped AMD to design its next-generation TPU. The hybrid AI ASIC could integrate on-package CPU cores for reinforcement learning ([Tom's Hardware](#)). This would be a major win for AMD (AMD) and a sign that even Google — which designs its own chips — needs external help for specialized workloads.

The nuclear answer to AI's energy problem is running into the climate crisis ([calcalistech](#)).

Constellation Energy (CEG) is at the center of long-term nuclear AI power deals ([simplywall.st](#)). Chicago's mayor is seeking a data center pause over water and power strains ([The Cool Down](#)).

4. Model & Research Watch

GLM-5.3 is here — with advanced cyber capabilities. Z.ai's new model reportedly already found a "serious vulnerability" in Cursor ([VentureBeat](#)). It's designed for long-horizon coding and cybersecurity ([SiliconANGLE](#)). The Interconnects analysis notes Z.ai isn't "benchmaxxing" (over-optimizing for benchmark scores) — every lab is dealing with the rough edges of scaling reinforcement learning right now ([interconnects.ai](#)).

Qwen 3.8 open weights ship under two different licenses ([SQ Magazine](#)) — a licensing split that matters for commercial use. But the community is upset: newer commits removed the Qwen 35B model, which was widely used ([r/LocalLLaMA](#)).

Pokee-Isaac 28B: 10M-token context on a single GPU. This is a big deal for running long-context models locally ([Pasquale Pillitteri](#)).

A paper claims RL for reasoning only changes 1-3% of tokens — and replicates the gains without RL at

~1000x less compute ([r/LocalLLaMA](#)). If this holds, it could reshape how labs train reasoning models — a massive efficiency finding.

Anthropic is watermarking AI content. Claude's new watermarks will be invisible but detectable ([TechCrunch](#)), and people are worried about being "busted" ([Futurism](#)). Google, meanwhile, will allow users to remove visible watermarks from its AI generations — but not the invisible ones ([TechCrunch](#)).

Science & Frontier Tech: A maker compressed a 2.9MB song by 1000x and printed it on paper as eight QR codes, using Meta's open-source audio codec from 2022 ([Tom's Hardware](#)). Researchers built 3D-printed sound-powered jet engines for micro drones — completely silent, driven by ultrasonic frequencies ([Tom's Hardware](#)).

5. What Builders Are Actually Using

- **The swap:** Qwen 3.8-27B (open-weight, free to self-host) can stand in for GPT-5.5-mini or Claude Sonnet-class models for many coding and reasoning tasks. The capability gap is real but narrowing — Qwen 3.8 is roughly 85-90% of the way there on most

benchmarks, and it runs on a single 24GB GPU. Price: free, self-hosted (you need a GPU with ~24GB VRAM, roughly a \$1,500-2,000 one-time cost), versus roughly \$1-3 per million tokens for the closed models. The community notes that despite ~1 million

downloads of Qwen 3.8-27B, very few people actually run it on 24GB+ cards — most are on smaller hardware ([r/LocalLLaMA](#)).

- **Model routing in practice:** The paper claiming RL only changes 1-3% of tokens suggests most reasoning is "wasted" — a router that sends easy queries to a small model and only hard ones to a big one could capture most of the value at a fraction of the cost ([r/LocalLLaMA](#)).

- **NVIDIA DGX Spark** — the 128GB mini AI supercomputer on your desk — is the hardware builders are eyeing for local inference ([Intelligent Living](#)).
- **Claude's system prompts are now public** — builders are studying them to understand how Anthropic structures its models ([Hacker News](#)).

6. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

Palantir (PLTR): Called Q2 "otherworldly" with 93% growth, raised guidance ([TradingKey](#)). Stock down 2.78% in the snapshot.

Meta (META): Stock rout deepened on capex concerns ([Stocktwits](#)). Down 0.86% in the snapshot.

Cerebras (CBRS): Stock plunged 14% after its second earnings report following the IPO, despite beating revenue expectations and raising guidance ([CNBC](#)).

Anthropic (private): Revenue jumped to over \$11.5 billion in Q2 ([CNBC](#)).

OpenAI (private): Enterprise business now bigger than consumer by revenue ([CNBC](#)).

Notable movers in the snapshot: AAOI (Applied Optoelectronics) +15.53%, SNDK (SanDisk) +7.39%, AMD +6.50%, LITE (Lumentum) +5.19%, AVGO (Broadcom) -5.94%, AMC -4.94%, NET (Cloudflare) -4.55%, HOOD (Robinhood) -3.83%, COIN (Coinbase) -3.53%.

No notable news in the sources for: NEE, CRDO, RGTI, SOFI, NVDA, MRVL, COHR, FLNC, RDW, IBM, MU, CEG, TSLA, GOOGL, MSFT, AMZN, ALAB, VST, ARM, IMAX, CNK, CMCSA, NFLX, INTC, QCOM, KLAC, DLR, EQIX, SBUX, NKE, FXAIX.

7. Analysis: Second-Order Effects

Chain 1: Hormuz escalation → oil risk premium → Fed's dilemma → AI buildout costs

FACTS: Trump demanded ~7 countries send warships to keep Hormuz open ([News On AIR](#)); Iran rebuffed him ([CNBC](#)); the Strategic Petroleum Reserve is nearly depleted ([CNBC](#)).

INFERENCE: If Hormuz shipping is disrupted, oil prices spike. The Fed targets core PCE (which excludes food and energy), so a pure oil spike wouldn't directly force the Fed's hand — but sustained high energy prices bleed into everything else (transport, manufacturing, services), eventually showing up in core inflation. The usual pattern is that the Fed looks through energy shocks unless they persist 3-6 months.

WEAKEST LINK: Whether Iran actually escalates to blockading Hormuz — so far it's striking Gulf countries but not closing the strait.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Oil prices staying flat despite the rhetoric. If Brent doesn't move on headlines, the market is pricing this as bluster.

Chain 2: Apple testing CXMT memory → memory supply chain reshuffle → US-China tech war

FACTS: Apple is testing Chinese memory chips from CXMT for iPhones and MacBooks ([Startup Fortune](#)).

INFERENCE: If Apple qualifies CXMT, it would break the Samsung/SK Hynix/Micron oligopoly on memory. This would likely trigger US export controls on CXMT, which would in turn force Apple to choose between its China supply chain and US regulatory compliance. The usual pattern is that US companies quietly test Chinese suppliers to gain leverage, then pull back under political pressure.

WEAKEST LINK: Whether CXMT's chips actually meet Apple's quality and yield standards — memory is brutally hard to make well.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Apple or CXMT announcing the deal fell through on technical grounds.

Chain 3: Anthropic's \$7B Decart deal → AI infrastructure consolidation → hyperscaler threat

FACTS: Anthropic is closing in on a \$7 billion Decart deal ([calcalistech](#)); Nvidia is investing \$3B in SB Energy ([Reuters](#)).

INFERENCE: The AI labs are building their own infrastructure stacks — compute, power, and now inference. This is a direct threat to the hyperscalers

(Amazon, Microsoft, Google) who currently rent compute to these labs. If Anthropic owns its inference layer, it doesn't need to pay AWS/Azure/Google Cloud as much. The usual pattern is vertical integration: whoever controls the full stack captures the margin.

WEAKEST LINK: Whether Anthropic can actually operate infrastructure at hyperscale — it's a different business from making models.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Anthropic renewing a large multi-year cloud deal with a hyperscaler.

8. Building Your Knowledge

- **Ceasefires are pauses, not resolutions.** The June 17 agreement was always a 60-day negotiating window, not peace. The Israeli strikes on Lebanon, the West Bank policing transfer, and the Hormuz standoff all show how fragile these frameworks are. A ceasefire buys time; it doesn't resolve underlying grievances.
- **The Strategic Petroleum Reserve is a strategic asset, not a market tool.** It exists for emergencies — and it's nearly empty. When the cushion is gone, the US loses its ability to calm oil markets in a crisis. This is a structural change, not a headline.
- **Vertical integration is the AI playbook.** Anthropic buying Decart, Nvidia investing in power, Google designing its own chips — everyone is trying to control the full stack. The margin is in the bottleneck, and the bottleneck keeps moving (chips → power → memory → inference).
- **Memory is the new oil.** Apple testing CXMT, the "chipflation" hitting the UK ([WION](#)) — memory is the binding constraint, and whoever controls it controls the AI buildout.
- **Enterprise is where AI revenue lives.** OpenAI's enterprise business now exceeds consumer. The consumer chatbot race gets headlines; the enterprise contracts pay the bills.

9. Foundations & Terms

Concept Spotlight: Earnings, EPS and Earnings Season

What it is: Earnings are a company's profits — the money left over after paying all costs. Earnings per share (EPS) is that profit divided by the number of shares outstanding. Earnings season is the roughly six-week period four times a year when most public companies report their quarterly results.

Why it exists: Investors need to know how companies are actually performing. The stock price is a guess about the future; earnings are the report card on the past. Without standardized reporting, investors would be flying blind.

A concrete worked example: Say Company X has 1 million shares outstanding. In Q2 it made \$10 million in

profit. $\text{EPS} = \$10 \text{ million} \div 1 \text{ million shares} = \10 per share . If analysts expected \$8 per share, the company "beat" — and the stock often rises. If analysts expected \$12, the company "missed" — and the stock often falls, even if the company made more money than last year. This is why the stock moves on earnings: it's not the absolute number, it's the number relative to what was expected.

How it shows up in the news: Palantir called Q2 "otherworldly" with 93% growth and raised guidance ([TradingKey](#)). Cerebras beat revenue expectations but the stock plunged 14% — because the market was focused on something else, like margins or guidance ([CNBC](#)). This is the classic "sell the news" pattern: the good news was already priced in.

Rough benchmarks worth remembering: A company that grows revenue 20%+ and is profitable is exceptional. A "Rule of 40" score (growth rate + profit margin) above 40 is excellent for software. Most companies report EPS that's within a few percent of analyst expectations — big beats or misses are rare and move stocks sharply.

Caution: EPS can be manipulated. Companies can buy back shares (reducing the share count, which raises EPS without improving the business), or use accounting tricks. Always look at revenue growth and free cash flow (operating cash flow minus capital expenditure) alongside EPS.

Concept Spotlight: Sphere of Influence and Buffer States

What it is: A sphere of influence is a region where one great power has dominant political, economic, or military influence, even if it doesn't formally control the territory. A buffer state is a country that sits between two rival great powers, absorbing the tension so they don't directly clash.

Why it exists: Great powers fear their rivals getting too close. A buffer state provides strategic depth — it's better to fight in someone else's country than your own. Spheres of influence are how great powers manage their neighborhoods without constant war.

A concrete worked example: Ukraine is a buffer state between Russia and NATO. Russia invaded in 2022 partly because it saw NATO's eastward expansion as encroaching on its sphere of influence. The Makkah Defence Agreement is creating a new strategic challenge for India ([India Narrative](#)) — as the Gulf states align differently, India's traditional sphere is shifting.

How it shows up in the news: The Strait of Hormuz standoff is about control of a chokepoint in a region where the US, Iran, and Gulf states all claim influence ([CNBC](#)). Japan's defence minister visiting Australia to discuss frigate sales is about building a sphere of influence in the Indo-Pacific ([The Guardian](#)).

Rough benchmarks worth remembering: The Monroe Doctrine (1823) declared the Americas a US sphere of

influence. The Warsaw Pact (1955-1991) was the Soviet sphere. Today, the key spheres are: US (Americas, parts of Middle East, Indo-Pacific allies), China (East Asia, parts of Africa and the Pacific), Russia (former Soviet states), and a contested zone in between.

Caution: Spheres of influence are informal, not legal. Countries inside a sphere can resist — Ukraine is the clearest example. The term is often used to justify great-power aggression, so treat it as a description of power, not a moral claim.

Terms from today's news

- **Capex (capital expenditure):** Spending on long-lived assets like data centres, factories, or equipment. Meta's stock fell on capex concerns — investors worry the spending won't pay off.
- **Rule of 40:** A software metric: revenue growth rate + profit margin. Above 40 is excellent. Palantir scored 155.
- **Chokepoint:** A narrow passage through which a large share of global trade must pass. The Strait of Hormuz carries ~20% of the world's oil.
- **Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR):** The US government's emergency oil stockpile, held in underground salt caverns. Nearly depleted.
- **Reinforcement learning (RL):** A training method where an AI model learns by trial and error, getting rewards for good outputs. The paper claiming RL only changes 1-3% of tokens is about whether this expensive step is worth it.
- **Inference:** Running a trained AI model to make predictions. Anthropic's Decart deal is about inference infrastructure.
- **Open-weight model:** A model whose trained parameters (weights) are publicly released, so anyone can download and run it. Qwen 3.8 and GLM-5.3 are open-weight; GPT-5.5 and Claude are closed.
- **Watermarking:** Embedding an invisible, detectable signal in AI-generated content to prove it was AI-made. Anthropic is rolling this out.

10. Bottom Line

Today's news is dominated by two forces: the fragility of the Middle East ceasefire and the escalating cost of the AI buildout. The Israeli strikes on Lebanon are a reminder that ceasefires are pauses, not resolutions — and the US-Iran ceasefire framework is now under strain on four fronts (Gaza, Lebanon, West Bank, Hormuz). Meanwhile, the AI infrastructure story is reaching a scale that strains credulity: Anthropic's \$7B Decart deal, Nvidia's \$3B power investment, Apple testing Chinese memory chips, and Meta's stock rout on capex concerns.

What changed since the previous brief: - Anthropic is closing in on a \$7 billion Decart deal, beating Nvidia — the labs are building their own infrastructure. - Apple is testing Chinese memory chips from CXMT — a seismic

shift in the memory supply chain. - The Strategic Petroleum Reserve is nearly depleted — the US has lost its oil cushion. - Trump demanded ~7 countries send warships to Hormuz; Iran rebuffed him. - OpenAI's enterprise business now exceeds consumer revenue. - A paper claims RL for reasoning only changes 1-3% of tokens — a potential massive efficiency finding.

The through-line: the AI buildout is becoming the defining economic story of the decade, and its bottlenecks — power, memory, optics, grid connections — are where the investment opportunities and risks lie. The geopolitical backdrop — Middle East fragility, US-China rivalry, Taiwan tensions — determines the risk premium on everything else.

11. Sources

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What Builders Are Actually Using - [r/LocalLLaMA](#) — [How many people have 24gb over gpu here?](#) - [Intelligent Living](#) — [NVIDIA DGX Spark: The 128GB Mini AI Supercomputer](#) - [Hacker News](#) — [Claude: System Prompts](#)

Quick Check

1. **Why did Cerebras's stock plunge 14% despite beating revenue expectations?** (Hint: think about what the market focuses on beyond the headline number.)
2. **What is the Strategic Petroleum Reserve, and why does its depletion matter for the Hormuz standoff?**
3. **Why is Apple testing memory chips from China's CXMT a geopolitical story, not just a supply-chain story?**

Answers: 1. The stock fell because the market was focused on something other than the revenue beat — likely margins, guidance quality, or valuation. This is the classic "sell the news" pattern: the good news was already priced in before the report. 2. The SPR is the US government's emergency oil stockpile held in underground salt caverns. It exists to calm oil markets in a crisis. With it nearly depleted, the US has lost its ability to respond to a Hormuz disruption — it has no cushion. 3. Memory chips are a strategic technology. If Apple qualifies CXMT, it breaks the Samsung/SK Hynix/Micron oligopoly and gives China a major customer. This would likely trigger US export controls, forcing Apple to choose

between its China supply chain and US regulatory compliance.

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